



Rules FAQ from designer (/→ /thread/3623856/rules-faq-from-designer)

Cthulhu: Dark Providence – Amazon \$59.98 – Affiliate Link

Travis R. Chance Designer / Publisher
@TRChance 7 dic 2025 (edited)

Hey! Travis here. Lots of questions about the game since its release. Thought I would compile some clarifications here for posterity! I will endeavor to keep this up to date.

ADD INFLUENCE ICONS: Asset cards like Explorers Club and Wall Street show influence (cube) icons. The action on these cards, as well as other cards that show this icon means to add up to that many influence cubes from your personal supply to a SINGLE card or city space. You cannot add influence to more than one card or city space from a single action or effect unless it specifically states otherwise (such as the Black Goat Mythos card).

CLAIMING CITIES: Players may add influence to city spaces for a city they have already claimed as a means to protect it. Placing a lock on a city you have claimed is also a great way to do this.

AGENT INFLUENCE: Agents count as influence for both the city and the asset cards in in which that agent is present.

CTHULHU: This Mythos card places the Cthulhu standee in a city. A player that controls this city loses control of it, as well as the points they gained. Players cannot move agent into or through the city space with the Cthulhu standee, nor can they influence that city further.

DEEP ONES: Deep Ones tokens are added to the board by the Deep Ones asset card. If all 8 tokens are on the board when this card is played it is an alternate game end trigger. Deep Ones count as special agents that do not count toward your 6 agent limit. They provide influence in city spaces like agents and can be assassinated like agents as well, but are not agents in any other regard. Deep Ones that are assassinated are returned to their respective player’s personal supply. Obliterated Deep Ones are removed from the game—making it impossible to place all 8 on the board. They are not recruited, so cards that specifically state recruited agents do not work on them. This also means if a player has only Deep Ones and their main agent, they may still be assassinated if they're past the requisite number of victory points. Specifically, Revenants, Mi-Go, Herbert West, and Corruption do not work on Deep Ones.

DISSIDENTS: Each dissident is an allegiance of one. If both dissidents are in the game, they do not apply the allegiance elimination to one another for having the lowest score. If a player claims the Mythos card Imposter and they are a cultist dissident, they become an investigator dissident (and vice versa).

MYTHOS CARDS: Mythos cards are not replaced after they are claimed. When the last asset card in a city is claimed or obliterated, add 1 new Mythos card to the Mythos row (and increase the Ritual track by 2). There are cards that can add Mythos cards to the game, such as Randolph Carter.

SANITY: Sanity tokens gained throughout the game count against your main agent’s limit of 3 insane tokens. Sanity tokens gained from Recruited agents opening/closing gates count towards this limit in addition to potentially obliterating that agent.

Anthony Rubbo Designer
@LemonyFresh 7 dic 2025 (edited)

Some additional clarifications below. Huge thanks to Travis for both his amazing work on the design, and his support provided here post-release!

SETUP: Players begin with 6 Influence - the scoretrack cube comes from the 7 initially taken from the general supply. Players select their starting locations in reverse turn order, with the Start Player of the game selecting *last*.

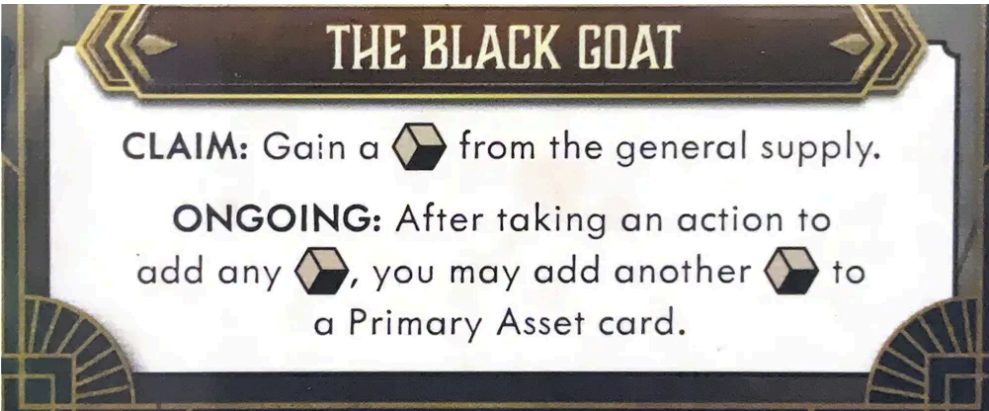
FREE ACTIONS: Free Actions may not be taken prior to a Claim action.

Anthony Rubbo Designer
@LemonyFresh 7 dic 2025 (edited)

Travis R. Chance @TRChance wrote:

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What about Mythos card "The Black Goat"? Unsure if it is specifically stating this or not.



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Anthony Rubbo [@LemonyFresh](#) wrote:

I _think_ you start with 6 influence? But there's room for doubt.

Setup states to take 7 influence cubes in your color. A few steps down, it says to place 1 of these 7 cubes on the score track. So yes, 6.

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I suppose I must've missed the word "these". Thanks!

(Edit: Doh, no, "these" isn't there in the final copy. It tells you where to put the two groups of cubes, and then at the end, says to place one on the track. Pulling it from either place felt wrong in their own way, given the language. And while there's a pic, I've been burned by setup pictures before. We went with 6 just because it's a third of 18 😊)

(Still, thanks!!!)

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Travis R. Chance Designer / Publisher
[@TRChance](#) 7 dic 2025

Apologies “another cube.” But the answer remains the same: this would allow you to break the rule and influence multiple cards.

Anthony Rubbo Designer
[@LemonyFresh](#) 7 dic 2025

Also useful for this FAQ (answered elsewhere) -- **You cannot take Free Actions prior to the Claim Action.**
(For every rulebook argument that a "Free Action" is a subset of type "Action", there's at least one implying the opposite. Definitely FAQ-worthy, especially given the history of this rule in previous incarnations.)

Travis R. Chance



Designer / Publisher

@TRChance

7 dic 2025

It says in the rules that Claim can be your first action only, so I feel this is clear.

Travis R. Chance



Designer / Publisher

@TRChance

7 dic 2025

I appreciate all the help. I work for a different publisher these days, but I want to support the game to the best of my ability. I even went out and bought the copy I have.

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(Still, thanks!!!)

This feels clear to me. And I am paraphrasing, not typing out the exact verbiage (apologies). It references these 7 cubes to go to players. Then each player to place 1 cube on the score track. No other cubes have been referenced in the player setup. I agree it could be more clear. But it conveys from 7 to 6 to me.

Anthony Rubbo



Designer

@LemonyFresh

7 dic 2025 (edited)

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It's I that appreciates you -- to be honest, I wasn't even sure if any support from anywhere was going to be present for this game whenever it got released.

i.e. If you had washed your hands with the game and moved on, I don't think *anyone* would have thought ill of you, and would have completely understood. The fact that you're here & helping is amazing.

I had preordered this instantly 2 years and 2 months ago, and (sorta) similar to you buying a copy before you get your designer's copies, I purchased a store copy while my preorder is still out there unfulfilled.

The game deserves to be played, dammit! And with this thread, we can help others be sure to play it as intended.

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I appreciate it! Study remains one of my favorite games and Martin my very favorite designer.

scott cozzolino 
@scottcoz 7 dic 2025

Thanks for the FAQ - much appreciated!

Here's another question for it:

Setup, step 12 says, "Starting from the first player and proceeding in counterclockwise order, each player places their Main Agent..."

- Does this mean the first player actually places their Main Agent first, or last? It says starting "from," not starting "with," so it's a little unclear.

Travis R. Chance   Designer / Publisher
@TRChance 7 dic 2025

First player places last

Hardboiled Gregg 
@HotHeart 8 dic 2025 (edited)

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Not exactly -- rather than "to another", it says "add another"...implying (perhaps) that if you are adding to a Primary Asset, you get to add an additional cube there.

It could've been clearer and maybe said "any" instead of "a" but the implication is that after you add influence, which can also be to Cities and Mythos cards, you also may add an influence cube to a Primary Asset card. Note that it also takes effect 'after the action' which would imply that the original action's cube placement location has no bearing on where the additional cube can go.

Overall, I think some of the oversight is through familiarity with the original version. I think it becomes clear for some of these effects that unless stated otherwise, it is always intended that recovering influence cubes can be from anywhere but placing influence cubes is always in one location per action/effect. Otherwise, you wind up with a truly chaotic bid/counter-bid type situation.

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Part of the interesting element of working with different publishers is they have their own processes and preferences. I am not a big fan of language neutral (let’s make this so no one understands), nor am I a big fan of interspersed icons in text. There is a cognitive lag. I prefer to spell out the intention of an effect with as many words as it takes. However, some of the effects in this game are complex as heck. Martin had to give sometimes a paragraph of clarification on Study—and rightly so. I think the nuance gets a little lost in the simplification of this version at times, but it certainly works for the majority of the content.

I think the CMON producers are top notch and they understand their audience best. During my time there I worked with a lot of super smart and talented people from all over the world. It was a privilege—truly. I do wish I had been around for the golden version of the rules. But I’m here now to help as best I can on behalf of the many amazing people that made this possible.

Mike F 

@rigol 9 dic 2025 (edited)

I don't know where this idea that Deep Ones can be assassinated and provide influence like agents comes from. I can't see either of those in the rules. Can anyone advise? All I can see is that you can use money to move them between cities and that they have the special actions to multiply and take cities.

EDIT: I see now that part of this is answered on page 12's Assassinate rules, which mention in an 'IMPORTANT' section that deep ones are special agents that can be assassinated.

Anthony Rubbo  

Designer

@LemonyFresh 9 dic 2025

See [Designer's Note](#).

Travis R. Chance  

Designer / Publisher

@TRChance 9 dic 2025

The rules state that Deep Ones are special agents and can be assassinated in the section on Assassinate.

scott cozzolino 

@scottcoz 11 dic 2025

After playing this evening, I have another question (apologies if this seems obvious):

First paragraph of the Claim rule states: "... they [agents] provide 1 additional influence while present in a city for the claim action." This led to a debate which we could not resolve - is the intent that agents provide additional influence WHEN a player takes the claim action and has agents present? Or that the agents additional influence is always "on" when they are present?

Example: Active player has 2 influence cubes on a city, but another player has 2 agents there. Can the active player claim that city, because agents only provide their additional influence when taking the claim action (thus, the other player has zero influence there during the active player's turn)? Or, can they NOT claim the city, because the other player has 2 influence there, from his agents?

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Always

Hardboiled Gregg 

@HotHeart 12 dic 2025

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To get nitpicky, a Claim action is still what's being assessed, so any agents there provide influence.

I agree that the rules leave it a bit vague and make it sound like it only cares about the active player's agents, though. The intention, going back to the original A Study in Emerald, is that agents are always considered to contribute influence to their location, for both the Primary Asset and the City card. In fact, they used to be tiebreakers, too.

Pedro Freitas 

@Petter_03 12 dic 2025

Hello Travis,

Yesterday I played the game for the first time with my friends, and we had some questions about the following cards:

Deep Ones

- When a Deep One is assassinated, does it return to the card owner, allowing it to be placed again, or is it permanently removed from the game?
- Regarding the city-conquering effect: do you need to have, for example, 3 Deep Ones in the specific city that costs 3 VP, or if you have 3 Deep Ones in any city, can you conquer any city that costs 3 or less?

R'Iyeh

- This card has all the symbols, but I can only use one symbol per action. Does this mean that even when using a simple effect, such as placing 1 cube, I still need to perform a sanity check?

Thank you, we loved the game!